

Eryngium maritimum (Apiaceae)

Sea Holly,

Eryngo

Description Evergreen perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has spiny silver leaves, and tiny flowers in summer.

Habitat Sea holly is found in coastal areas of Europe, preferring sandy soils. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Sea holly contains saponins, coumarins, flavonoids, and plant acids.



Sea holly has distinctive silver leaves and is often seen in coastal areas of Europe.

History & Folklore In 17th-century England, sea holly root was candied and eaten as a sweetmeat. It was also consumed as a means of preventing scurvy. In his *Irish Herbal* (1735), K'Eogh states that the herb "provokes urination and menstruation, encourages flatulence, and removes obstructions of the liver, kidneys, and bladder." In K'Eogh's time, sea holly was a popular medicinal herb, and was considered helpful in the treatment of a wide array of neurological conditions, including paralysis and convulsions.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In contemporary European herbal medicine, sea holly is used as a diuretic. It is prescribed as a treatment for cystitis and urethritis, and taken as a means to alleviate kidney stones. It is unlikely that the herb actually dissolves established stones, but it probably helps retard their formation. Sea holly is also used to treat enlargement or inflammation of the prostate gland, and may be of benefit in treating chest problems.

Erythraea centaurium

(Gentianaceae)

Centaury

Description Biennial herb growing to 9½ in (24 cm) with a basal rosette of leaves and 5-petaled pink flowers in clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and southwestern Asia, centaury is now found in temperate regions throughout the world. The plant is harvested in summer when just about to flower.

Parts used Aerial parts.

Constituents Centaury contains many bitter constituents, including secoiridoids, also found in gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99).

History & Folklore In classical myth, the centaur Chiron used this herb to treat a poisoned arrow wound.

Medicinal Actions & Uses One of the most useful bitter herbs, centaury has a relatively mild bitter action, stimulating appetite as well as digestive secretions from the salivary glands, stomach, intestines, and gallbladder. With increased digestive juices, food is processed and broken down more effectively, leading to better absorption of nutrients. For best results, centaury should be taken over several weeks. The preparation should be slowly sipped so that the components (detectable at a dilution of up to 1:3,500) can stimulate reflex activity throughout the upper digestive tract.

Self-help Uses Weak digestion, p. 306; Gas & bloating, p. 306.

Erythrina variegata (Fabaceae)

Indian Coral Tree,

Dadap (Hindi)

Description Deciduous tree growing to 59 ft (18 m). Has prickly stems, leaves with triangular leaflets, and pea-like red flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Indian coral tree grows in deciduous forests throughout much of the Indian subcontinent.

Parts Used Bark, leaves.

Constituents Indian coral tree contains alkaloids, isoflavonoids, triterpenoids, and lectins. The alkaloids are anti-inflammatory and analgesic, and the isoflavonoids display antibacterial activity.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Ayurvedic medicine, Indian coral tree is used to treat inflammatory conditions, period pain, and problems related to eating and digestion, including anorexia, flatulence, colic, and worms. The bark is used to treat skin problems and fever. A paste made from the leaves is applied to heal wounds.

Erythronium americanum

(Liliaceae)

Trout Lily

Description Perennial growing to 10 in (25 cm) from a small, bulblike corm. Has two oblong leaves mottled with purple and a large, bright yellow lily flower.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, trout lily is found mainly in the east, from New Brunswick to Florida. It prefers damp woodland and open ground. The leaves are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Very little is known about the constituents of this plant. It contains alpha-methylenebutyrolactone.

History & Folklore Trout lily was little used by Native Americans. European settlers considered its medicinal properties to be similar to those of meadow saffron (*Colchicum autumnale*, p. 193). Trout lily was listed in the *Pharmacopoeia of the United States* from 1820 to 1863 as a treatment for gout.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An infusion of the leaves is taken for skin problems such as ulcers and tumors, and for enlarged glands. The leaves (or the whole plant) may also be applied as a poultice for skin conditions. The fresh leaves are strongly emetic.

⚠ **Caution** Take trout lily only under professional supervision.

Erythroxylum coca

(Erythroxylaceae)

Coca

Description Evergreen shrub growing to 10 ft (3 m). Has alternate oval leaves, small white flowers, and small red berries that each contain a single seed.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Peru and Bolivia, coca grows in high-rainfall areas of the eastern Andes to altitudes of 4,900 ft (1,500 m). It is mostly cultivated for the illegal market. The leaves are picked when they begin to curl.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Coca contains cocaine and various other alkaloids, a volatile oil, flavonoids, vitamins A and B₂, and minerals. The plant's stimulant and anesthetic action is due largely to cocaine.

History & Folklore The indigenous peoples of the Andes carry pouches containing coca leaves and lime, which they chew throughout the day. Early European travelers noted that individuals chewing coca never had tooth or gum problems,